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PHILOSOPHY OF LANGUAGE:

Fundamental Concerns

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CHAPTER 4

THE PROBLEM OF TRANSLATION

Quine in his theory of the “indeterminacy of translation”, calls attention to the great problem there is in translating from one language into another language, especially into a language that is “radically different” from the source language. This is what he (Quine) calls “radical translation”.¹ If Quine’s theory is correct, then a great problem faces the African philosophers who in most cases have to translate into European languages the concepts that are purely African, purely African because they purely have to do with African experience and culture.² Before we go into the examination of the problems of translation, there is need to briefly explain what the term “translation” means.

What is Translation

Jakobson (1959) distinguishes three kinds of translation which he explains as follows:

- 1) Intralingual translation or *rewording* is an interpretation of verbal signs by means of other signs of the same language.
- 2) Interlingual translation or *translation proper* is an interpretation of verbal signs by means of some other language.

¹ W. V. Quine, *Word and Object* (Cambridge, Massachusetts: The M.I.T. Press, 1960), 28.

² The translation from any of the African languages into an Indo-European language, however, is not all that a radical translation. Although there are enough differences between most of the languages of Africa and the Indo-European languages due to differences in cultures and in the structures of the languages concerned, these languages have been in contact for some hundreds of years now. Radical translation obtains between two languages that are coming into contact for the first time.

3) Intersemiotic translation or *transmutation* is an interpretation of verbal signs by means of signs of nonverbal sign systems.³

Of these three kinds of translation we concern ourselves with the number two, i.e., with interlingual translation or translation proper.

Translation by its very nature always involves a *transfer* of meaning,⁴ a transfer underscored by the prefix *trans*. To translate is to *superimpose* meaning, a fact which is well expressed in the German word for translation - *Übersetzung*.⁵ Translation can be defined as a decoding from one language and encoding into another.⁶ In this act of decoding and encoding, three major tasks, according to Eugene A. Nida, are involved:

- (i) the analysis of the message in the source language (SL),
- (ii) the transfer of the message, and finally
- (iii) the restructuring of the transferred message in the receptor language (RL).

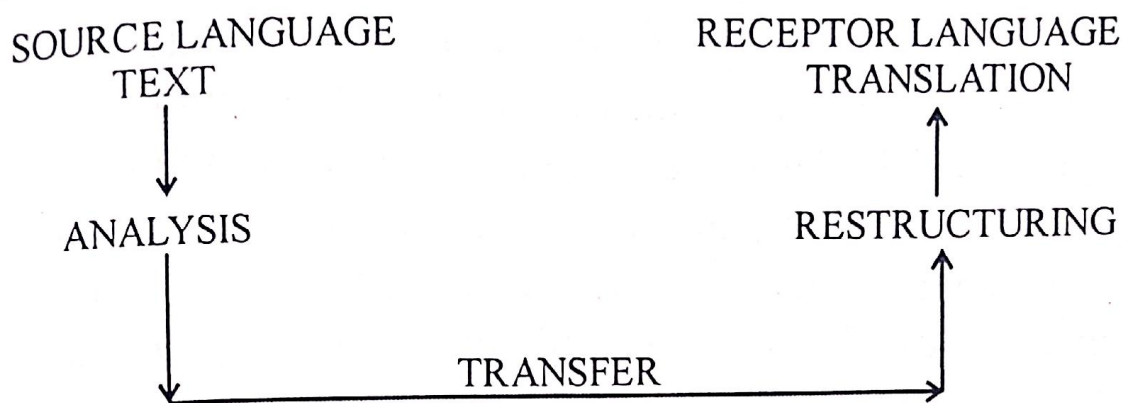
³ R. Jakobson, "On Linguistic Aspects of Translation", in R. A. Brower (ed.), *On Translation* (New York: A Galaxy Book, Oxford University Press, 1966, First published in 1959), 233.

⁴ To say that word, a phrase or a sentence has a "transferred" meaning is to say that the meaning in question is different from the original meaning. This is the problem facing each translation: there is always some difference in meaning between the original word and the word that translates it.

⁵ Confer J. Derrida, *Parages*, Paris: Galilée, 1986, p. 137 footnote.

⁶ Cf. E. A. Nida, "Science of Translation", *Language: Journal of the Linguistic Society of America*, 45 (1969), p. 483.

The following Illustration explains these three points.



Illustration⁷

In translating, the translator analyses the message or the concept as it is in the SL. Next, he transfers the result of his analysis towards the RL. Finally, he tries to restructure the transferred meaning in accordance with the structures of the RL.

That is to say, the translator first analyses the message of the SOURCE language into its simplest and structurally clearest forms, transfers it at this level, and then restructures it to the level in the RECEPTOR language which is most appropriate for the audience which he intends to reach.⁸

Translation, therefore, is essentially a process of the transfer of meaning, message or concept from the SL into the RL.

The Problem of Incomplete Equivalence

In the transfer of meaning/message from the SL to RL, most of the translators are more concerned with the receptors of the message in the RL than with the original nature of the message in the SL. Translators with this end in view do a lot of interpretation of the original message and their translation often becomes their own understanding of the message in the source language. On the other hand, some translators pay more

⁷*Ibid.*, p. 484.

⁸*Ibid.*

attention to the nature of the original message. They aim at being as faithful as possible to the original message of the SL that they make their translation almost meaningless to its receptors in RL. This is a serious dilemma normally faced by any translator. It is in this sense that Nida defines translation as "reproducing in the receptor language the *closest natural equivalent* of the message of the source language...."⁹ I emphasize "closest natural equivalent" in order to make it clear that there is no complete equivalence between the message as it is contained in the SL and the message as it is restructured and rendered in the RL. Jakobson makes this point clear when he says: "on the level of interlingual translation, there is ordinarily no full equivalence between code-units".¹⁰ The problem of incomplete equivalence is in the very nature of translation.

Translatus is the root of the term translation and this Latin term simply means "carrying across." Each translation is fundamentally a carrying across of meaning or message. In interlingual translation the message or meaning in the original language is transferred to another linguistic system. The philosophical problem of translation is that of finding out to what extent one can transfer intact the original meaning from the source language (SL) to another linguistic system (RL). Language does not simply code meaning, but forms part and parcel of meaning. According to Ferdinand de Saussure, the

⁹ Ibid., p. 495 (emphasis, mine). Confer also E. A. Nida, "Principles of Translation as exemplified by Bible Translating.", in *On Translation*, Op. Cit. pp. 11 - 31, with specific reference to page 19.

¹⁰ R. Jakobson, "On Linguistic Aspects of Translation", *Ibid.*, p. 233. For further information on the problems of incomplete equivalence confer S. Bassnett-McGuire, *Translation Studies*. Revised edition (London and New York: Routledge, 1991), 23-29; M. B. Dagut, "Can Metaphor be Translated?" *Babel*, 22 (1976), pp. 21 - 33; and J. C. Catford, *A Linguistic Theory of Translation* (London: Oxford University Press, 1965).

structural relationship between the meaning/concept (*signifié*) and the word (*signifiant*) constitutes a unitary linguistic sign. The signified and the signifier are so closely related that the transformation of the one may not take place without some effect on the other. Words are not simply containers of meanings but makers or givers of meanings. "There is no *signatum* without *signum*."¹¹ To what extent do we succeed in transferring intact the *signatum* (meaning/message) from the original *signum* (sign/language) into another *signum*? Here is the philosophical problem of translation.

Other Problematic Elements in Translation

A text lives only if it survives, and it survives only if it is at the same time translatable and untranslatable.... Totally translatable, it disappears as a text, as a document, as the body of language. Totally untranslatable, ...it dies immediately. — Jacques Derrida.¹²

The problem of translation arises because of the nature of natural languages. Each natural language is different from every other one in its phonological, syntactical and semantic structures. There is also the difference in the level of the standardisation and literary genre of the natural languages. Furthermore, there is the problem of the differences in culture, for each system of *signum* (each language) forms part and parcel of a culture and has its adequate signification within this culture. This leads to the problem of the transgressions, modifications or superimposition of meanings - the problem of incomplete equivalence - when a *signatum* is transferred from one *signum* into another. Translation, nevertheless, is a fact

¹¹ *Ibid.*, p. 232.

¹² J. Derrida, "Journal de bord", in his *Parages*. Paris: Galilée, 1986, pp. 147-148. The whole article "Journal de bord" is printed as footnote from pages 119-218.

lives with us. The question is: what, according Jacques
rida, can be translated and what cannot be translated?

tactical, Semantic and phonological problems

translator is faced with many problems when translating
a RL that differs widely from the SL. Some languages
pronouns which distinguish masculine/feminine/neuter
(English, German), while others have pronouns and articles
which distinguish only masculine/feminine (French). There are
other languages which make no gender distinction in their
use of pronouns (here fall most of the African languages). The
English and Yoruba pronoun **O** stands for English he, she, or it.
Some languages (French, German etc.) make gender distinction
in their use of adjectives while others (English and most of the
African languages) do not. Where the English talk of a tall
man, a tall woman and a tall girl, the French talk of *un grand*
homme, *une grande femme* and *une grande fille*; while the
German talk of *ein grosser Mann*, *eine grosse Frau* and *ein*
kleines Mädchen; and the Igbo talk of *ogologonwoke*, *ogologo*
nyiri and *ogologo agboghobia*. The English adjective *tall*
qualifies all the three nouns without changing its form; the
same is the case with the Igbo adjective *ogologo*. The French
adjective *grand* has to change its form to distinguish between
masculine and feminine, and the German *gross* has to change
like the masculine, feminine and neuter forms. In German
and French, adjectives have gender connotations, in English
they don't (except in some few cases like handsome for male
and beautiful for female). In African languages such gender
connotations with adjectives do not exist. This distinction is
not just a trivial linguistic distinction, but affects people's
attitude to things and events in the day-to-day life. The
connotations that go with a word is very important in
translation and have some deep philosophical importance as we
shall shortly see. Another syntactical structural difference is
that of the gender agreement between the possessor and what is

possessed. While the English make such an agreement only with the possessor, the French do so with what is possessed, while the German do the agreement both ways. Thus, *John's wife* becomes: in English his wife, in French sa femme, and in German seine Frau.¹³ An English or a German cannot translate the French sentence - "*Sa voiture est là*" - without extra task of finding out whether the owner of the car is a man or a woman. In almost all the African languages such an extra information is not needed in order to translate this French sentence.

The problem facing the English and the German translators of "*Sa voiture est là*" is the type of difficulty which Jakobson says a translator has to confront when translating "into a language provided with a certain grammatical category from a language devoid of such a category".¹⁴ To translate the English sentence - "I hired a worker" - into French, the translator needs to find out whether the worker is a male or a female so as to choose between *ouvrier* (male worker) and *ouvrière* (female worker). The same is the case with the Russian translator who has to choose between *rabotnika* (male worker) and *rabotnicu* (female worker). In addition, the Russian needs to know whether the action of hiring was accomplished or not so as to be able to choose between the completive verb *nanjal* and the non-completive verb *nanimal*. The Russian and the French terms used in referring to *a worker* each carries more information than the English term.

¹³ In all these three languages - English, French and German - the concept wife is feminine. But in English the pronoun for it is masculine agreeing with the possessor (John), in French it is feminine agreeing with the concept itself, while in German the pronoun is masculine agreeing with the possessor but with a feminine ending taking care of the gender of the concept *wife*.

¹⁴ R. Jakobson, *Ibid.*, p. 235.

The effect of the gender distinction on the thinking of the speakers and on the attitudes towards reality is well described by Jakobson. It serves as a basis for a people's whole theology and religious practice: "The fact that the word for Friday is masculine in some Slavic languages and feminine in others is reflected in the folk traditions of the corresponding peoples, which differ in their Friday ritual."¹⁵ Gender distinction is the basis of the superstition among the Russians that "a fallen knife presages a male guest and a fallen fork a female one" because knife is masculine in Russian language while fork is feminine. Jakobson also makes mention of the title of a book of poems: *My Sister Life*, by Boris Pasternak. This title is normal in Russia because in Russian language the word for "life" is feminine. But this same title is a source of despair for the Czech poet Josef Hora in his effort to translate this work because the word for "life" in Czech language is masculine.¹⁶ This shows that the phenomenon of gender, though a syntactical factor, transcends mere linguistic domain to influence the people's philosophy of and attitude to life. Such influence is what, in most translations, is either lost or distorted.

A person translating into Igbo from most of the Indo-European languages faces a similar problem with regard to the verb to be. To translate the French sentence "*Il est dans la maison*" into Igbo, the translator needs to know whether the pronoun "*il*" refers to an animate object that is capable of auto-locomotion in which case he has to use the verb *no*, or to any other object in which case he has to use the verb *di*.¹⁷ One can also think of

¹⁵ *Ibid.*, p. 237.

¹⁶ *Ibid.*

¹⁷ This extra information is needed here because in Igbo language there are two possible verbs - *no* and *di* - which are used to localise an object. If the object is capable of auto-locomotion the verb *no* is used, if not *di* is used.

the problem of the translation of the English "Yes" into German where one has to choose between *Ja* and *Doch*, or into French where one needs to choose between *Oui* and *Si*. The problem arises here when the question is in the negative form, for example, "Haven't you taken your breakfast?". Assuming that the person to whom this question is addressed has taken his breakfast. If he is an English he replies "Yes", if a French "Si", if a German "Doch". While the English use the same word "yes" in the case of contradiction of a negative question as they do in the affirmative to other forms of question, the French and the German have special word for contradicting a negative question. For the Igbo and the Japanese, the case is different: both try to agree or disagree with the question. If the above question is addressed to an Igboman who has taken his breakfast he would answer in the negative, for in the structure of his language he has to negate the negative question in order to make it positive. Thus to answer that he has taken his breakfast he responds "Mba" (no). The mathematical-logical rule of double negation yielding an affirmation is tacitly applied here. If he has not eaten he answers "Ee" (yes) in agreement to the negative question that he has not taken his breakfast, for negative + positive is always negative. The logic can be illustrated as follows:

P: Obi had breakfast.

Question	Answer	English	Igbo
P?	Yes/Ee No/Mba	P $\neg P$	P $\neg P$
$(\neg P)?$	Yes/Ee No/Mba	P $\neg P$	$\neg P$ $\neg\neg P = P$

In the same sense the Japanese person would answer *Iye* (no) where the Igbo answers *Mba* and *Hai* (yes) where the Igbo

person answers “*Ee*”¹⁸. In the case here described, the Igbo normally don’t just say “*Ee*” (yes) or *mba* (no). They make a sentence like: “No (*mba*) I have eaten.” Or “Yes (*Ee*) I have not eaten.”

The philosophical importance of the grammatical structure of each language in the question of translation is that “the grammatical categories carry a high semantic import”. Syntax and semantic are in most cases so intertwined. This fact is made clear in the following Latin sentence: *Puellapuerumamat* and its English equivalent: “The girl loves the boy”. The point is that while the positions of *puella* and *puerum* can be changed (*Puerumpuellaamat*) without any change in the meaning of the fact stated, the change in the positions of “girl” and “boy” in its English equivalent brings about a grave change in the fact stated. The natural language one speaks affects, to some extent, his cognitive dispositions because, each word of every language raises some questions for its speakers with regard to some grammatical agreements and disagreements.¹⁹ The phonological structure is what constitutes the great structural problem in translating from most African languages into Indo-European languages. In tone language phonological changes go with semantic change.²⁰

¹⁸ For more light on the problem of the response to the negative form of question and on the problem of the translation of the English “Yes” confer W. V. Quine, *Quiddities: An intermittently Philosophical Dictionary* (London: Penguin Books, 1987), 142 -144; and S. Bassnett-McGuire, *op. cit.*, p. 16.

¹⁹ Cf. R. Jakobson, *ibid.*, p. 235.

²⁰ On the phonological problems involved in translating from African into Indo-European languages confer R. Allsopp, “Africanisms in the Idiom of Caribbean English.” In P. F. A. Kotey & H. Der-Houssikian (eds.), *op. cit.*, pp. 430 - 31

On considering the translation problems arising from linguistic structures, it is important to talk of the differences in the level of the standardisation of literary genres of different languages. It is obvious that the literary genres of most African languages are not of the same level with the Indo-European languages. There are, therefore, some difficulties involved in trying to squeeze in some of the African concepts into the specialised literary genres of the European languages. Such an attempt often goes with the deformation of the original message in the SL. A literal translation of some of the African concepts, especially their idioms are "often much obscured in detail in the standardised lexicographical renderings given in those languages [Indo-European languages]."²¹ Owing to the structural differences between the natural languages, translators are often bound to transform either the normal structure of the receptor language or the original message in the source language.²² In most cases both the structure of the receptor language and the original message are transformed. In poetry where the aesthetic aspect of language is concerned, the structures of languages and the level of the standardisation of their literal genres constitute the greatest problem in translation.

Cultural elements in Translation Problems

Where the translator meets the most difficult problem is with regard to the aspects of culture. When translating into the RL whose culture is widely different from that of SL, the translator faces the problem of representing to his receptors what is completely outside their experiences. E. A. Nida states this problem clearly in the following passage.

²¹ *Ibid.*

²² J. Derrida says that translation "oblige à transformer la langue traduisante ou le véhiculer récepteur, à déformer le contrat initial... dans la langue de l'autre". *Parages*, op. cit., pp. 131 - 135.

In translating a text which represents an area of cultural specialization in the source language but not in the receptor language, the translator must frequently construct all sorts of descriptive equivalents so as to make intelligible something which is quite foreign to the receptor.²³

Since language constitutes the heart of a culture, each word of every language is culturally charged. This being the case, the word used in the RL goes with certain cultural connotations that are totally absent in the word of the SL that carries the message one wants to translate. Language, as a system of symbols, is "culturally conditioned"²⁴. In my opinion, it is this cultural aspect that constitutes what J. Derrida refers to as the "untranslatable." This cultural aspect is one of the major contributing factors to Quine's theory of indeterminacy of translation.²⁵

Words have their full meaning within the cultural background of the language they form part of. It is for this reason that Heidegger holds that translation from one language into another not only leads to the destruction of the philosophical force of the original word, but leads in addition to the departure from the original philosophy to another form of philosophy.

²³ E. A. Nida, "Science of translation", *op. cit.*, p. 491. The described situation is exactly what many Africans do in their effort to translate into Indo-European languages the aspects of their cultures which form the bulk of the traditional African philosophy and theology. I am not against such an effort. My bone of contention is that of not presenting the original in writing before trying its translation. The translation is always the transformation of the original which can never be fully its equivalent.

²⁴ E. A. Nida, "Principles of translation as exemplified by Bible translating", *op. cit.*, p. 13.

²⁵ W. V. Quine, "Meaning and translation", in *On Translation*, *op. cit.*, pp. 148 - 172, with specific reference to page 149. See also W. V. Quine, *Word and Object*. Cambridge, Massachusetts: The M.I.T. Press, 1960, Chapter 2.

The translations of the Greek philosophical texts, for instance, have, according to Heidegger, distorted and bastardised the Greek philosophy. The philosophical imports of the original Greek words are lost in words of the receptor languages, e.g., the Greek φύσις and *natura* which is its Latin equivalent.²⁶ Each translation succeeds to some extent to render the general meaning of the word or the general sense of the sentence, but there is the cultural aspect of the original word or sentence which is lost in the translation. "The basic principles of translation", writes Nida, "mean that no translation in a receptor language can be the exact equivalent of the model in the source language. That is to say, all types of translation involve loss of information...."²⁷ Let me take the Igbo word "*Udu*" to illustrate the point at issue. This one word carries a bundle of positive and impressive meanings and emotions like solidity, originality, fidelity, truth, reliable, trustworthy etc. When on beholding an object, an event or a performance the Igbo person says: "*Nke a buudu*" (This is *udu*), or simply "*Udu!*", he has said it all in the positive. A volume can be its translation in another language, yet the term *udu* remains non-exhausted and inexhaustible. It is the Igbo cultural set up that charges the term *udu* with meanings. Here is the example of Derrida's translatable and untranslatable. The same is the case with the Igbo word "*efulefu*" which the famous novelist, Chinua Achebe, renders as "worthless, empty men".²⁸ Another

²⁶ M. Heidegger, *An Introduction to Metaphysics*, tr. by R. Mannheim, New Haven, Yale University Press, 1959, p. 13. Confer also A. Benjamin, *op. cit.*, pp. 14 - 22.

²⁷ E. A. Nida, "Principles of Translation....", *op. cit.*, p. 13.

²⁸ C. Achebe, *Things Fall Apart*. New York: Fawcett Crest, 1959/83, 133. After translating the word "*efulefu*" as "Worthless, empty men" Achebe feels that this has not yet properly translated this Igbo word. Thus he goes on explaining: "The imagery of an *efulefu* in the language of the clan was a man who sold his machete and wore the sheath to battle." *Ibid.*

example is Judo-Christian religious terms "*Alleluia*" and "*Amen*". *Alleluia* can be translated into English as "Praise the Lord" and *Amen* as "So be it". These translations lose the religious weight of the original terms with all the cultural and historical undertones that go with them. This may explain the French re-adoption of *Amen* in place of "*Ainsisoitil*" which is the French translation of *Amen*. In the course of a seminar S. B. Oluwole²⁹ rightly pointed out that such concepts as "family", "dowry", and "bride price" do not have the same meaning for Africans as they do for the European. The difference comes from the cultural tags these concepts have in African and European cultures respectively.³⁰ It is in line with this that Quine points out the danger of "reading our own provincial modes" into others' language. He (Quine) illustrates this point

²⁹ Seminar on the "Interdisciplinary Co-operation in African Oriented Research", organised by the Faculty of Philosophy, University of Lagos, Nigeria, on 29 January 1997.

³⁰ Because the African concept of family is by far wider than that of the Western, the terms "brother", "sister", etc. that have to do with family relationships which don't have the same meaning for the Africans as they have for Europeans. When an African person says "my brother" he does not necessarily imply "the son of my mother". The concept "brother" for an African includes a brother, a half-brother, a cousin, a male person from the same village, town, state, tribe, country, or even continent as himself. The scope of the term "brother" depends on where the African finds himself. When he goes out of his village into another, all the males from his village there become his "brothers", when outside his country, all his compatriots there become his "brothers", and so on. This is obviously a distortion and transgression of the English word "brother" which is not so expansive as its equivalents in African languages. It was once a family case against me because I introduced my cousin as "my cousin" and not as "my brother". I did so because I was bound to speak English in the given circumstances of the introduction, and I wanted to respect the proper meaning of the English term "brother". I was, however, misunderstood by my cousin who interpreted my action as divisive and sign of segregation. He won the case before our "family" members. He was an African while I was a "European" with regard to the term (and not the concept) "brother".

with the term "half-brother" which for the Islanders refers to pelicans, in addition to its normal reference to the son of the stepfather or stepmother.³¹

As I was in Belgium, I was often faced with the difficult task of responding to the question: "*Comment dit-on 'Bon appétit' dans votre langue?*" (How does a person say 'Bon appétit' in your language?) What is difficult here is not finding the Igbo words for *bon* and for *appétit*. It is rather the absence of the practice of saying anything like *Bonappétit* in Igbo culture. Thus, to the above question my usual answer was that we don't say such a thing in our language, because it doesn't exist in our culture. Were I to say to an Igbo person who is eating: "*Aguunriguagi*" which is a close transliteration of *Bon appétit*, he will not only not understand what I mean but he is also likely to take offence from such a saying because in Igbo culture he who has much desire for eating is not highly valued. The English have the same problem as the Igbo with *Bon appétit*. *Good appetite* which is the literal English equivalent of *Bon appétit* is never a wish in English language, as such, it doesn't mean at all to the English what *Bon appétit* means to the French.³²

A similar problem confronts the translator into Igbo with the short English sentence "I love you" which lovers say to each another. Such a saying does not obtain in Igbo culture. Lovers show their love in deed, not in words. To tell someone "*Ahuru m gin'anya*" - the literal Igbo translation of "I love you" - completely distorts the original meaning in English. "*Ahuru m gin'anya*" has no passionate and sexual undertone, and desire for intimacy as its English equivalent "I love you." Because the practice of saying "I love you" does not exist in our culture,

³¹ W. V. Quine, *Word and Object*, p. 77.

³² Confer S. Bassnett-McGuire, op. cit., pp. 21 - 23.

those who have learnt to say it do so in the language of the culture in which they learnt it, and not in our language. It is this cultural aspect that constitutes the bone of contention between Heidegger and his Japanese interlocutor.³³ Commenting on his translation of Heidegger's lecture on Hölderlin's "Homecoming" the Japanese says: "And while I was translating, I often felt as though I were wandering back and forth between two different language realities...."³⁴ The Japanese illustrates his point with the great difference between the Japanese word *Iki* and the Indo-European word "Aesthetic" which ordinarily is supposed to be the equivalents of each other but which, in actual fact, differ from each other in many respects.

Meaning in Translation

Some known writers identify meaning with that which is transferred from a sentence in the SL to RL in the process of translation. Quine, for instance, writes: "The meaning of a sentence of one language is what it shares with its translations in another language...."³⁵ R. Jakobson manifests a similar opinion when he says that "the meaning of any linguistic sign is its translation into some further, alternative sign...."³⁶ What Quine and Jakobson (and all who share this opinion) are telling us is: for you to understand what a meaning of a word is, look for what the word in the source language has in common with its translation in another language. Meaning is therefore defined by means of translation. If the meaning of a word or a

³³ Cf. M. Heidegger, *On the Way to Language*, op. cit., pp. 1 - 54.

³⁴ *Ibid.*

³⁵ W. V. Quine, *Pursuit of Truth* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1992), 37. Confer also *Word and Object*, op. cit., p. 32 where Quine writes: "For meaning, supposedly, is what a sentence shares with its translation. . . ."

³⁶ R. Jakobson, "On linguistic aspects of translation", op. cit., p. 232.

sentence is identified with what the word or the sentence in the source language shares in common with its translation in the receptor language, then the whole concept of meaning is put to question by the problems of incomplete equivalence, of the untranslatable, and of the loss of information in translation. Worse still, the objectivity of meaning is put to question by Quine's theory of indeterminacy of translation. Quine, as it were, is saying that there is no objective or real meaning that would be the same in all the languages. He buttresses this point by making allusion to Wittgenstein's view: "Understanding a sentence means understanding a language," and understanding a language is understanding a culture.³⁷

The problem of incomplete equivalence arises from the fact that a word hardly means *exactly* the same thing in the original language and in the language of translation. The English word "structure", for example, is not coterminous with *la structure* which is its French equivalent. In some cases this word means the same thing in both languages, while in other cases its meaning in one language differs much from what it means in the other. In some of the cases where the French use the word *structure* the English use "system" as in "systematic problem" whose French equivalent is "*le problème structurel*". The same is the case with the English word "power" and the French *le pouvoir*. In most of the cases where the English use the word "power" the French use *la puissance* instead of *le pouvoir*. If the meaning of a word is its translation in another language, what is the meaning of "power" in French? It is not just *le pouvoir*, it is more than that. Another example is the French word *savoir* and its English equivalent "know".

³⁷ W. V. Quine, *Word and Object*, *op. cit.*, pp. 76 - 77. Confer L. Wittgenstein, *Blue and Brown Books*, p. 5, and *Philosophical Investigations*, paragraph 199.

Even the common French word *le pain* (bread) is said by the German thinker, Walter Benjamin, to have different connotations with the German word *Brot* in spite of the fact that in most cases they have the same 'intended object'.³⁸ Jakobson also says that the English word "cheese" is not completely identified in meaning with its standard Russian heteronym "*сыр*".³⁹ No word in the source language has an identical meaning with its so-called equivalent in the receptor language. A word is not coextensive with any particular meaning or reference. A word's full semantic force is always larger than any particular reference. A. Benjamin is thus right when he talks of the "potential for the word to signify beyond itself".⁴⁰ A word has varieties of meanings to be determined according to its use within a sentence in a given language and within a language-game or a universe of discuss. It is for this reason that in dictionaries varieties of meanings are given out of which a person chooses according to the context. In translation some of these varieties of meaning of a word are lost because in every translation there is some change in context, at least cultural context.

Any translation inevitably goes with certain loss of information. Information is lost in translation because the circumstances within which a word is used in the source language is, in most cases, not taken care of in the translation, in the effort of the translator to render the message meaningful to the receptors in RL. Nor does translation convey all the

³⁸ Confer W. Benjamin, "The task of the translator", in *Illuminations* tr. by H. Zohn (London: Fontana, 1982), 74. The original German text: "Die Aufgabe des Übersetzers", in *Gesammelte Schriften*, Band IV. 1, Frankfurt, Suhrkamp, 1978, p. 14.

³⁹ R. Jakobson, *op.cit.*, p. 233.

⁴⁰ A. Benjamin, *op. cit.*, pp. 160 - 161.

emotions and social tags that go with the word in the SL. Let us take the French "*Bonsoir*" and the English "Good evening" as a point of illustration. "Good evening" is the normal translation of *Bonsoir*. But a Frenchman who comes into an English country and begins using "Good evening" the way *Bonsoir* is used among the French will in many cases embarrass his addressees. While the French greet *Bonsoir* both in meeting a person and in parting company from him in the evening, the English greet "Good evening" only in meeting and never in parting company. There are other subtle differences between these two modes of greeting which a person discerns only by living both the French and the English cultures. It is for reasons like these that Heidegger goes to the extreme position of viewing every translation as a mutilation, a transgression, even a destruction, of the original meaning of a word, as illustrated in his contention against the translation of the Greek φύσις with the Latin *natura*.⁴¹ Heidegger's, however, is the other extreme position as opposed to the view that translation is transferring meaning whole and intact from one language into another. The true position must be somewhere between these two extremes.

Although each language is borne out of and develops within experiences and situations special to the people whose language it is, there are, nevertheless, shared experiences and situations for all *homo sapiens*. The fact of differences does not deny the fact of resemblances. There are always the "translatable" and the "untranslatable". The translatable testify to the universality of the human experiences and the

⁴¹ Cf. M. Heidegger, *An Introduction to Metaphysics*, op. cit., p. 13. In another place Heidegger writes: "... it is not enough to exchange the Greek words for other words in other languages, however familiar. Instead, what is needed is that we let the Greek words tell us directly what *they* designate." *What is called Thinking?* op. cit., p. 228.

universality of the language phenomenon, while the untranslatable call attention to the diversities in natural languages and cultural backgrounds. The fact that Heidegger is able to dialogue with the Japanese underscores the point that there is the possibility of dialogue between a German and a Japanese. Dialogue is, therefore, possible between the German language and culture and the Japanese language and culture. This also implies that there are some common elements in both languages and cultures. Thus the Japanese tells Heidegger: "And while I was translating. . . at moments a radiance shone on me which let me sense that *the wellspring of reality from which those two fundamentally different languages arise was the same.*"⁴² If Heidegger's major concern is that of pointing out the fact that a move from one language to another exposes "that which is in question to be transgressed by a particular linguistic practice"⁴³, then he is right; but not that translation completely destroys the original meaning, in which case he would be wrong. Heidegger is correct to the extent he calls our attention to the fact that translation is not a simple carrying of meaning from one language into the other.

Underlying the view that a translator takes out a meaning that is contained in one language, carries it and puts it into another language, is the view that word does nothing but codes the idea or the thought. This is a dualistic approach to the problem of language, a view that an idea is an entity resting somewhere, in the human mind/brain; an entity, as it were, which a word or a sentence codes or labels. It is this entity which is the meaning that is believed to be transferred intact from one code to another in the process of translation. Quine attributes this type of misguided view to what he calls "mentalistic philosophy"

⁴² M. Heidegger, *On the Way to Language*, op. cit. p. 24, (emphasis, mine).

⁴³ A. Benjamin, op. cit., p. 33.

which focuses its attention on "private worlds".⁴⁴ Words are not just paper bags or containers of meanings or messages that can easily be removed from one container into another without any deformation of the content. The change of the *signum* goes with some modification of the *signatum* because both constitute a unitary linguistic sign (de Saussure). Meanings and messages are what they are within a given language and its words. Language and its words together with meaning form a unity, a sort of an inseparable whole.⁴⁵

The meaning of a sentence is more than what the sentence in the source language shares with its translation in another language because its meaning is never fully shared and, as such, can never be *fully* translated. This is not to say that a reasonable acceptable translation is not possible. Translation is not only possible, it is the fact of our interpersonal and international relations and we come to understand one another to a great extent by its means. The problems of incomplete equivalence, of lack of full information and of the "untranslatable" only underline the importance of the original text in the source language and the need to consult it from time to time so as to avoid a situation where the original message is gradually departed from by series of translations and translations of translations, thus making the original message completely unknown.

It becomes, therefore, the task of the African philosopher to come up with African philosophy that is documented in an

⁴⁴ W. V. Quine, *Word and Object*, p.79.

⁴⁵ In this sense Heidegger is correct when he says that "words and language are not wrappings in which things are packed for the commerce of those who write and speak. It is in word and language that things first come into being and are." M. Heidegger, *An Introduction to Metaphysics*, op. cit., pp. 13 - 14.

African language in which the African experiences are lived. Such a document would serve as a point of reference for original research on African philosophy that deals with those philosophical problems and experiences that are essentially African.